house ‘was home to me’, Ratan reminisces fondly. He spent most of his holidays, like Thanksgiving, with this family. It was in Baltimore that Ratan learned to drive and got his first driving licence from the State of Maryland, which meant so much to him that he has preserved the document bearing No. EE.18.79-1551 to date.

Settling in at Cornell

Ratan joined Cornell in September 1955 to study mechanical engineering. He became a member of the Alpha Sigma Phi fraternity. Philip (Phil) Handler from the BArch 1964 batch, Ratan’s junior who had extensively researched on Ratan’s college life and made a film on him titled *Ratan ’59: The Cornell Story*, narrated a seldom-told account of the difficulties Ratan faced in the initial days. Since Ratan was an ‘Indian’ and had ‘dark skin’, he had a ‘lot of problems initially’, Handler said. The society of that time (1950s) was not ‘very accepting of people of colour’, he recalled. Even though Ratan was so ‘well off, so cultured’ and hailed from a ‘great background’, people were biased; but a member of the fraternity stood up and ‘said that he’s a great guy, and that swayed the other fraternity brothers’, Handler remembered.

Once admitted, he was assigned a room in the sixth block of the Rockledge fraternity building. It was next to that of the dorm counsellor, Dick Barger. The first week was ‘scary’, Ratan reminisces. His anxiety was not in any way eased by the public stance of his dorm counsellor who took pride in declaring that he was both a ‘policeman and helper’. Some also said that he was a tyrant, which only increased the young Tata’s anxiety. The constant feeling that there was someone always watching over you and that he happened to be your neighbour and counsellor, was uncomfortable, he adds.

The traditions of the college too were alien, which worsened his anxiety. He found the need for all freshmen to wear red pea caps, with the year of enrolment written on them, a little unnerving. It was like displaying the vulnerability of freshmen on the forehead for all to see. He felt homesick too, something virtually all freshmen suffer in the initial months, especially if they are staying away from home for the first time. Though Ratan had already spent more than a year at Riverdale, these were very ‘difficult days’ as there were many adjustments that had to be made, he recalls. Unlike